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ETERLIVO

Reading Sample



Chapter One

Dawn broke over the western hills where Zako stood sentinel, arms locked across his chest and boots sunk into the morning-wet soil. Wind cut through his brown hair, carrying whispers of old enmities that demanded new solutions.

Each day brought the same exhausting battle with the Flipeans. An endless cycle he'd grown tired of repeating.

Joras trudged up beside him, cradling Jumbi in one arm. The orange Ballo purred as Joras's fingers traced circles across its round surface.

"There they are again," he muttered through clenched lips. His chin jutted towards the horizon where winged figures wheeled above Fieldburg's gleaming spires that housed the Flipeans and every headache they had.

Beneath them stretched Eterlivo, the Land of Eternal Olives.

It was a place so vibrant that the very mountains seemed to breathe. Trees crowded the hillsides, their branches reaching skyward as though grasping to pull down star-seeds to plant in the rich earth below. Singing rivers cut silver paths through emerald meadows, weaving a colourful carpet.

At the heart of it all stood the Great Olive, a grim reminder of the day peace was lost. Its thick, gnarled trunk bore the marks of time, and its bare branches stretched outwards, devoid of even a single green leaf.

Joras sifted through the dirt for stones, testing their weight in his palm before pocketing the best ones. "Let's face it, Zako! Peace with those feathered tyrants? Might as well chase rainbows."

At that very moment Gianto's heavy footfalls announced his arrival as he crested the hill, his breath ragged. He only caught the tail end of the conversation, but it was enough to ignite a spark in his eyes. Gianto had always been obsessed with old legends.

"But the Great Olive once sheltered both our peoples," he said, gesturing towards the skeletal tree. "Our forebears swore that without its roots, there'd be no fertile soil left. The Flipeans say its branches gave them the secrets of flight. I've heard tales of a time when--"

"Spare us," Joras cut in with a dismissive flick of his wrist. "Bre came, they stood together against him, then the tree died, and then they weren't together anymore. We know the story, Gianto."

Gianto, however, was on a roll, charged with the fervor of a village elder recounting sacred history.

"Against Bre, they fought as one!" He insisted. "Our ancestors and theirs! Side by side! The scrolls tell of how the Great Olive mourned after Bre's touch, shedding leaves like a mother's tears, and how from that day on, hatred took root! What's your take on this, Zako?"

Zako's lips remained sealed. The words of his inauguration oath to forge a lasting peace came back to him unbidden. He had meant every word. He still did. Yet as another taunt drifted down from above, his jaw tightened. These daily flights of the Flipeans over Springton couldn't go on like this. He wanted peace, but not at the cost of his people's dignity.

His eyes wandered across the misty landscape of Springton below, where the Sparthean homes were draped in morning haze like delicate lace over a weathered crown. His gaze moved eastward to where Fieldburg's crystal towers rose from the forest canopy. Above them both, the same endless sky stretched out, and the same sun rose and set.

Their settlements stood barely an hour apart by foot, yet an unbridgeable gulf yawned between their souls.

The Spartheans were earthbound by nature. Literally. They had no wings, but what they lacked in flight, they made up for in heart. They walked the world with mud-caked boots and soil-worn hands but their laughter rang warm as the fresh bread they shared. Beside them rolled their faithful companions, the Ballos. These orange spheres were living creatures with oversized eyes and dimpled surfaces that gave them an almost childlike appearance. Legend holds that these creatures emerged from the Great Olive's ancient roots. Wherever Spartheans gathered, Ballos followed; their presence was as much a part of village life as the sunrise.

Unlike the Spartheans, the Flipeans soared on wings that transformed with their emotions. Joy painted them gold, scattering light like shattered sunbeams, while serenity washed them in silver like moonlight on silk. Rage, however, ignited veins of crimson through the delicate membranes, making them resemble a storm warning visible for miles. The Flipeans gloried in them and never let anyone forget it.

Tila swooped at the head of the morning patrol, banking towards them with practised grace. Sunlight fractured across her outstretched wings, casting prismatic patterns on the ground below. For one terrifying yet beautiful second, she resembled the sky itself, taking form and lodging in Zako's chest.

But then she spoke, and that reluctant recognition of beauty vanished the instant her mouth opened.

"Still hugging the mud this morning, groundlings?" Her voice cut through the air as her eyes locked onto Zako's, daring him to respond.

Zako didn't give her the satisfaction of an answer. Instead, he raised his chin, pivoted away and presented his back to her. He knew that was a snub that cut deeper than any insult he could shout. Tila's wings stuttered mid-beat and her confident expression faltered. This deviation from their familiar ritual of hurling insults at each other and having dramatic confrontations had caught her completely off guard.

Vinira swooped beside her, the iridescent patterns on her wings dissolving as crimson streaks pulsed through their delicate membranes.

"Did he just--?" she snarled in disbelief. "What's the matter, Chief? Too scared to face us?"

She dived towards them, her shadow darkening the ground, until a stone whistled past her ear. She jerked sideways, her wings flapping wildly as she tried to regain her balance. Below her, Joras kept hurling stones, his arm moving up and down in a steady rhythm, launching each stone with precision.

Even the Ballos themselves, despite their undeniable charm, couldn't escape the bitter insults pouring from above.

Zlathano's mouth twisted into a sneer as he hovered above them, his shadow falling across Danko, who trembled against Zako's ankle.

"Look at those orange blobs! What a bunch of useless lumps!"

Zako's boot slid protectively in front of the Ballo while Gianto loaded his slingshot; the pale stone gleamed in the leather pouch.

"One more word," Gianto growled, pulling the strap taut, "and you'll be spitting teeth."

Ronalkis shook out his wings and grabbed Leonessis by the shoulder, pulling him back. Leonessis pushed forward again, casting Gianto in shadow with his wingspan as he thrust his face inches from his. Joras flung himself between them.

“Let it go,” Zako said quietly, though his jaw clenched with each measured breath as he tried to cool the heat in his chest.

“Oh, give me a break! Every single morning the same!” Lesla muttered, as she watched the winged figures bank for a third pass over the village. “Why? I don’t get it.”

“Because they love us deeply and can't bear to be apart,” Joras deadpanned. “We’re just that lucky, I guess.”

Tila swooped closer, dangling the weathered basket tauntingly in front of them.

That old basket was their pride and joy. Woven from darkened oak strips, it swung beneath them wherever they flew. It was always there, always full of... something. No one knew what. The Flipeans guarded its contents as if they held the answer to a question too bold to ask. When not in use, it perched on top of a tall, gleaming metal pole, out of reach for anyone without wings. They would sooner chew off their own feathers than let a 'dirt-dweller' peek inside.

Springton was abuzz with rumours about its contents.

Some claimed that it housed the ancient elixir that could breathe life back into the Great Olive's withered limbs. Others believed it contained scrolls documenting the Flipeans' treachery.

Lebronikos, however, had a different theory.

“I’ve run the numbers!” he exclaimed glancing over both shoulders. “It must contain either the tree’s revival formula or...” He whispered, leaning in, “Or... it contains the spell that would grant us flight!”

“Yeah, or...” Joras interrupted, flicking a walnut at him. “Or it’s just full of their lunch. I’d bet on stale bread and a side order of disappointment.”

The joke sparked different reactions each night. Sometimes there was too much laughter, too loud and a little too desperate. At other times, an awkward silence would ensue, leaving Zako staring thoughtfully at the sky. He knew that the path to peace wouldn’t be easy and that the basket might hold the key to ending the feud between Earth and Sky.

That night, Zako perched on the low stone wall in the square until midnight and beyond. His eyes never left the eastern horizon, where Fieldburg’s metal pole stood like a needle piercing the velvet night sky.

Beside him, Danko the Ballo had tried every trick in his book, even rolling figure-of-eights between Zako’s ankles, but he couldn’t coax a smile from him.

The Ballo nudged his head against Zako’s knee, and his orange heart clenched as Zako’s thoughts flooded into him: He saw Tila struggling with her wings pinned back and Zako clutching the basket triumphantly. Danko recoiled, his round body trembling.

“No,” he whispered. “That’s not you, Zako. You’re better than that.”

His gaze drifted across their village. The fields lay fallow under a blanket of weeds, and a thin layer of rust coated the forgotten ploughshares and sickles. Their beloved home was fading away.

Danko and Jumbi nodded gravely at one another.

The situation was dire and they knew they had to act. They would help with every fibre of their being, even if it meant taking drastic measures.

They set off before dawn. Two spherical figures rolled northward with surprising speed, resolute in their mission.

The first ravine nearly ended their quest. Danko teetered on the edge before Jumbi nudged him to safety. They found themselves wedged in rabbit holes and faced a boulder

poised to crush them, yet they never lost heart until frost-covered grass signalled their arrival at the Frifies' domain.

The Frifies, eternal and impartial, observed all of the world's disputes from their crystalline, ice-bound towers, bound by an eternal oath of neutrality.

"State your grievance," intoned their leader, each syllable coiling in the air like frozen smoke.

The Ballos pleaded for intervention, but those ice-blue eyes remained unreadable.

"Your situation merits observation," the Frifies finally pronounced, and the assembled council dissolved into the heart of the blizzard. A perfect snowflake landed on Danko's head and clung there, frozen and final, like a full stop written by nature upon their desperate plea.

The journey back to the village passed in silence. Even when the village finally came into view, the cold still bit deep into their bones.

As night fell, they met the others in the village square. Despite everything, that ritual remained unchanged. The air was filled with the sweet scent of night-blooming flowers and the distant call of an owl. The scene might have been peaceful if it were not for Danko, who was unable to keep still.

"Fine! The Frifies were a bust! That leaves me with no choice but to fly myself!" he burst out, bouncing in front of Zako.

The absurdity of it broke through Zako's gloom, and that familiar lopsided smile of his spread across his face.

"You do know, my sweet starfruit, that you're spherical and wingless... right?" he chuckled. "Flying isn't exactly in your design."

“Says who?” Danko jumped, each leap higher than the last, almost touching Gianto’s chin on the fifth jump.

“The laws of physics, perhaps” Joras snorted. “I’m not entirely sure.”

Gianto’s massive hands plucked the orange ball from mid-air, his eyes gleaming with mischief.

“Let them talk. I think you’re right,” he rumbled, a grin spreading across his face.

“Let’s show them.”

With a heave that could have sent a pumpkin into orbit, Gianto launched Danko into the air.

“Hey, look! I’m flying!” His voice trailed off as his silhouette was momentarily etched against the silver moon. For two and a half seconds, he was right. Then came the thud. The sound made everyone gasp and they all squeezed their eyes shut as if they had been the ones to feel the impact.

Moments later, the bushes rustled from the spot and Danko rolled back into view, adorned with leaves and twigs like medals of honour.

“Did you see? Did you see how high...?” He babbled excitedly.

Gianto rubbed the back of his neck, wincing slightly. “Maybe the landing could use some refinement.”

“Right! Because that was the only flaw,” Joras deadpanned, and swatted Gianto on the back of the head.

The village square was filled with laughter until Lesla’s faded away.

“It’s so beautifully simple. We don’t even need wings,” she whispered, twirling a strand of her copper hair around her finger.

“We just have to launch them high enough to reach the basket!” she exclaimed, her pupils dilating as she looked from Danko to Jumbi, who were still chuckling unsuspectingly.

“Seriously? That's the solution to our existential torment? Launching the Ballos?”

Lebronikos said, his fingers tapping a nervous rhythm against his thigh.

“And why, pray tell, didn't we think of this sooner?”

“Because we're exceptionally intelligent,” Joras replied, raising his left eyebrow high enough to create three distinct wrinkles across his forehead, triggering fresh peals of laughter.

That night, with flushed cheeks and a wild new hope in their hearts, the Spartheans did something they hadn't done in a very long time.

They made a plan.

Starlight spilled across their gathering as Zako snapped twigs, mapping out attack positions in the dirt. Gianto's long fingers worked the frayed rope into loops and knots, muttering calculations under his breath. Perched on a nearby stone, Lebronikos punctuated the moment every few seconds with a dramatic sigh, each one deeper than the last.

“If this works...” Zako said. “The basket's secrets will be ours by tomorrow's sunset.”

A chill raced across Clara's skin, raising goosebumps on her forearms.

“Whatever lies inside might heal our world or shatter it completely,” Zako continued. “Either way, dawn will bring an end to our waiting.”

The next day at dusk, the sky above Eterlivo was painted in shades of lilac and rose.

Deep within the dense foliage of Fieldburg, Gianto pulled thorns from his tangled hair, muttering under his breath. He'd already wedged himself between rocks twice. Clara shrank back as Joras thrust his palm towards her face, proudly displaying three wriggling insects that he had just discovered. Meanwhile, a thriving colony of beetles had taken up residence in the deep folds of Lebronikos's coat, prompting him to brush at his sleeves.

At Zako's raised fist, they all held still like statues, barely drawing breath. The wingbeats of the last Flipean patrol passed overhead like frozen breath. One wrong move now wouldn't just mean a failed mission.

Lebronikos's throat went dry and his left eyelid twitched as he met Gianto's dread-filled stare. He was aware of the tales of past failures and severe punishments from his grandfather's book.

Everyone knew that the Flipeans didn't joke about guarding their territory. They patrolled with their usual swagger, confident in their dominion of the skies, completely unaware that their precious basket was now in the crosshairs of a few very determined mud-dwellers.

As the last patrol disappeared into the distance, Zako crept forward, his face streaked with mud and sweat, his eyes fixed intently on the prize. He made his way toward the basket while Danko bounced between his palm and the ground as though tugged by an invisible string.

Zako cupped Danko in his hands with ritual solemnity and lifted him to eye level.

"Ready?"

Danko met his gaze and nodded confidently.

Then Zako launched him with enough force that he should, in theory, have reached the basket.

In practice, however, Danko shot past it like a bullet, not even brushing it, and landed behind the pole.

"Status report!" Gianto demanded. "What did you see?"

Danko's voice came from deep within the bushes.

"Confirmed visual contact with... soil. Mostly dirt. And leaves. Lots and lots of leaves. Falling from heights is also a thrilling experience."

Lesla gripped her sleeves and pushed them up to her elbows. “Again! Failure won’t stop us!”

And indeed, they unleashed their orange arsenal. What followed was a spectacular display of complete scientific inaccuracy. They took turns launching one Ballo after another like orange rockets into the evening sky, landing everywhere but the basket.

From his vantage point atop the mulberry branch, Lebronikos shook his head. “I don’t see this working.”

“It will,” Joras said, wiping sweat from his brow.

Then, finally, Lebronikos decided to join the action. He leapt dramatically from the tree and intercepted Lesla’s next throw. The orange sphere landed in his palms with a satisfying thwack.

Joras nudged Zako with his elbow, leaned in and whispered something in his ear, that made him smile despite the tension. They both folded their arms and watched Lebronikos’s awkward stance with poorly disguised amusement. Under any other circumstances, one might have said they were having fun that evening.

Then Clara’s face drained of colour. “Wings,” she hissed, the word barely escaping her throat. “They’re coming!”

With two fingers, Zako sliced the air downward. They all vanished into the undergrowth, pulling foliage over themselves. Clara clapped a hand over her mouth as the beetles from Lebronikos’s collection began to climb up his neck, just as Tila’s shadow passed inches above their hiding place.

“I’m telling you, I heard something,” Tila’s voice drifted down from above.

Vinira’s wings rustled. “Fan out! Search!”

“Oh, come on... The basket is secure and the perimeter is clear. What more do you want?” Ronalkis grumbled. “Probably just foxes. Let’s go before we miss dinner.”

Zlathano hesitated for a moment, his fists clenched as he scrutinised the shadows in the undergrowth. Then, startled, a swallow burst from the foliage, drawing his gaze upwards. The tension broke, and his shoulders slumped in relief.

“Yeah, you’re right. Besides, no one else would dare,” he scoffed.

The sound of their wingbeats faded into the distance and their voices dissolved into murmurs, being swallowed by the forest’s silence.

Only then did Zako tap twice against the tree trunk. One by one, they emerged from their hiding spots like mushrooms after a summer rain: Gianto from behind a boulder; Lesla from beneath fallen branches; and Lebronikos, still brushing beetles from his collar.

“Well?” Joras murmured.

“We’re out,” Zako said. “Now, before another patrol.”

They fled, their footfalls urgent against the path back, not daring to breathe properly until they were welcomed by the embrace of the western hills.

Shards of amber light pierced the morning mist, dappling the dewy clearing with golden pools, as the Flipeans soared towards the rolling, emerald hills.

Suddenly, a tremor seized Tila’s wings, sending her into a brief and terrifying freefall before she caught herself. Squinting against the sun’s glare, which transformed the hilltops into platinum ribbons, she shielded her eyes with one hand. Her gaze travelled methodically across the slopes, searching for any trace of Zako’s silhouette. But saw nothing. Nothing stirred. The hills were empty.

“It can’t be...” she whispered, her heartbeat accelerating in time with her wingbeats as dread coiled inside her.

Behind her, Vinira nudged Ronalkis lightly with her elbow. Their eyes met for a brief, loaded second before they hurried to catch up. Leonessis rattled his chestnut-filled pouch in disappointment. He had been eager to counter Joras's pebble assault, but apparently this battle would not be fought today.

They raced towards the forest, the wind rushing past their ears. They spotted intense activity in the clearing between the two great oak trees.

Gianto's broad shoulders gleamed in the golden sunlight as he scrubbed grime from forgotten tools. He and Clara were heartily laughing about yesterday's failed 'rockets', despite the fact that they had never caught a glimpse of what was inside the mysterious basket.

With her fingers stained purple from berry juice, Clara knelt down and began to draw mysterious patterns in the dirt.

Nearby, Lesla twisted vines into a basket-like shape, occasionally holding it against Danko's round head to check the size. Lebronikos paced between the trees, with his arms outstretched and his eyes narrowed in concentration, as he visualised baskets hanging from branches miming throwing motions along invisible arcs.

Above them, the leaves shivered as Zako scaled one of the oaks, a bottomless basket slung across his back. Below, Joras called out instructions, gesturing emphatically as Jumbi bounded from the ground into his palm with metronomic precision.

"Morning, mud-dwellers!" Tila called, but every head remained bent to its task, as if nothing noteworthy were in the sky.

"Guess they didn't hear you," Ronalkis ventured, hoping to avoid further drama.

Tila cupped her hands around her mouth like a megaphone.

"I said, good morning!" she hollered, startling the birds from their nests in a flurry of wings.

On top of the oak, Zako tested his handiwork by tugging sharply on the basket's bindings twice. His lips curved with satisfaction when he found them secure and then he finally raised his gaze and met hers.

“Oh, good morning, Tila. You’re here? I didn’t notice you...” he drawled.

His irritatingly charming lopsided grin did not help at all today; if anything, it made things worse.

“What?!” Tila screeched, her wings blazing red. Ronalkis grabbed her by the wrist and hauled her away before she could dive-bomb Zako. The others followed, completely thrown off balance.

“Don’t hurry back!” Joras shouted after their retreating forms.

“Or ever!” added Gianto, his dark lashes framing his mischievous eyes as he batted Joras's raised palm away.

Seizing her opportunity in that moment of distraction, Clara intercepted Jumbi mid-bounce, just before he landed in Joras’s palm. She ran beneath the basket, gently tapping Jumbi with her hand at each bounce until they reached the target. With a practiced shove, she sent Jumbi flying straight into the basket. Meanwhile, Gianto’s attempt to block her ended with him spectacularly belly-flopping into the bushes.

Lebronikos leapt up and applauded rapidly. “Point awarded!”

Gianto heaved himself up, spitting out bits of foliage and dirt. “Absolutely not!” he protested. “Unless Jumbi counts as a player!”

Clara planted her hands on her hips. “Well? Does it count?”

Zako raised his eyebrows. “The time has come to establish rules for our game,” he proclaimed. “Lesla, we will need parchment and a quill.”

Lesla unfolded a weathered sheet of parchment and pressed its curled edges flat against her knee.

“All right, then.” Zako crossed his arms over his chest. “Present your arguments.”

In the centre of the clearing, Jumbi and Danko took their places as solemn judges. Their pupils dilated and contracted as they communicated telepathically. Joras bit his lower lip, fighting back a laugh. Gianto turned away hastily, avoiding his gaze, and stared at a pebble by his foot.

“The verdict is two points,” Jumbi and Danko announced in perfect unison.

“The first point goes to the thrower,” Jumbi declared.

“The second belongs to us,” Danko finished, punctuating the decree with two ceremonial bounces.

Zako rubbed his jaw. “Fair enough. Any objections?”

Lesla’s quill hovered over the inkwell before elegantly dancing across the parchment; her voice was barely audible. “Rule number one: players may only advance by bouncing.”

Hours passed. They continued to play, their shouts of triumph and groans of defeat echoing through the forest till the sun dipped below the horizon.

Not one of them glanced upwards with longing.

The game had given them their own way to fly. They had found wings in each other.

Meanwhile, the Flipeans gathered in their high open-air debate tower, their wings hanging as heavily as faded flags after a downpour. Tila paced back and forth, her nervous steps carving a path through the moss, muttering under her breath.

“Whaddya know!” she shouted, then dropped her voice to a mock-serious baritone.

“Ah, good morning, Tila. You’re here? I didn’t notice you,” she mimicked, thrusting her jaw forward to match Zako’s scowl. She tossed her hair back. “Go figure. The Grand Master Zako.”

Their precious basket swayed between Vinira’s trembling fingers, undeniable proof of the injustice they had suffered. “Not even this earned a glance today!”

“Let’s take it easy for a moment...” interjected Ronalkis, turning his ‘Vision-Thing’, as he called the tube he’d built for studying stars, towards the clearing. It was a masterpiece of engineering that had taken him three seasons to craft from hollowed acorns, binding the ends with birch bark rings and polishing the crystals exclusively with the highest-quality golden snails’ slime.

He adjusted the screw ring, and through the crystal, the clearing appeared so close he felt he could touch it. A faint orange blur of motion caught his eye and he leaned in closer, leaving a pale ring mark around his eye socket.

“Why are they tossing those Ballos back and forth?” he wondered aloud.

“Give it to me!” Vinira snatched it from his hands, shoving him aside so abruptly that he nearly toppled over. The moment she peered in, her wings flushed a ruby-red like glowing coals and snapped shut, in offence.

“This is outrageous!” she shrieked.

“They look... happy,” Martina observed, but she regretted it the instant the words left her mouth. Five pairs of furious eyes turned on her like hawks spotting prey. Zlathano’s wings vibrated fiercely, whipping up a mini-whirlwind that tousled her hair.

“Happy?! Really?! Just because they’re tossing those useless Ballos around?!”

Martina very, very discreetly wiped a few droplets of spit from her cheek with the tip of her wing.

Zlathano picked up a fairly large stone, speckled with lichen.

“This can do the exact same thing!” he fumed, slinging the stone towards their own basket. It would have shattered the basket, but luckily for him, Leonessis was an ace dodger and managed to snatch the stone at the very last moment. He stood protectively in front of the basket, with his hands on his hips and his foot tapping rhythmically against the ground as he stared Zlathano down.

“Fine! No stones,” Zlathano conceded, shaking the dirt from his hands.

“Let’s steal the Ballos! That’ll--”

“Have you completely lost your mind?!” Tila cut him off. “They treasure them like sacred relics! Dare to touch one! Just touch one and...”

She stopped abruptly and thrust the Vision-Thing towards him. “Look! Have you seen their hands?”

He shoved it away, lifting his chin.

“I know. I don't need to see.” He grabbed a handful of leaves and squeezed them in his palm, trying to shape them into a ball. “Then this. Look!”

But the leaves scattered and fell pathetically to the ground, three meters short of the target. Zlathano’s wings dimmed.

“Well... maybe we underestimated the Ballos,” he admitted reluctantly.

Tila caught her own reflection wavering in Ronalkis’s watery eyes. She barely recognised the face she saw. She frowned.

“Why did we do this?” she finally voiced the question she’d been holding inside.

“What were we thinking all this time?”

No one’s wings shone as they usually did. No one had an answer. The realisation that they’d wasted so many seasons painting the sky with their arrogance while the earth blossomed right beneath them settled upon them like a sack of potatoes. Even their precious basket felt heavy now.

A ragged sound that tried to pass for laughter clawed its way from Zlathano's throat.

"Uh... we had reasons... it was funny..."

But Tila's sharp gaze cut him off.

"No. Let's not kid ourselves anymore. We were just bullying them!" A hot wave of shame rose in her chest.

"And what does that make us? I... I don't know anymore." She shook her head, trying to force her thoughts into order.

"What if... we asked to play with them?" she suggested, looking toward the clearing. "We need to apologize."

"Apologize?! To those mud-dwell--" Zlathano started, then swallowed the insult. Suddenly, his old joke felt ice-cold, almost embarrassing.

Vinira, though known for her sharp tongue and tough streak, folded her wings tightly against her back.

"What if they laugh at us now?"

"Well... can you blame them?" Leonessis shrugged. "I vote we face them. Whatever happens, happens."

Ronalkis tapped Zlathano gently on the shoulder.

"Our pride led us astray," he murmured. "The path back begins with humility, whether they welcome us or not. Apology is always a good place to start."

They approached Springton with slow, measured steps. The Spartheans' game ground to a halt, their laughter fading into the crisp mountain air and, as if in response to an unseen signal, every eye turned towards the edge of the path, where the Flipeans stood. Their heads

held high in pride, yet their wings remained slightly flared at their sides, a posture that no Flipean would ever assume willingly, for it revealed their vulnerability.

Zlathano was the last to arrive, making a noisy landing that kicked up a cloud of dust. He skidded to a halt, toppling over in an awkward somersault that would have been hilarious under any other circumstances. Today, however, it made the Ballos huddle anxiously behind Zako's boots.

Lesla's half-closed eyes gave them a once-over, darting from the gilded tips of their wings down to their earth-stained feet, making no attempt to hide her hostility.

"Well?" she asked, her voice sweet as vinegar.

"To what do we owe the pleasure? What brings you to our humble... earth?"

Zako signalled to Lesla to hold back. Then he stepped forward, stood before Tila and met her gaze, waiting patiently.

Tila cleared her throat, but despite all her mental rehearsals, the words remained stuck. Her cheeks now looked like two overripe pomegranates. All she managed was to awkwardly extend her hands, offering the basket.

Zako's heart hammered in his ears. He squeezed his eyes shut, certain that he was seeing things. When he looked again, the basket was still there solid, real and offered. His gaze flicked between it and Tila's flushed face, searching for the trap, the trick, the jest that had to be hiding somewhere in this impossible moment.

Finally, Tila's voice returned.

"...Nuts and fruit. Common things. Here!... See for yourselves."

The revelation fell like a thunderbolt. The Spartheans remained frozen to the spot for several seconds until Joras broke the silence with a triumphant shout.

"Ha! Didn't I say it? What did I tell you?" He crowed, though no one else had recovered enough to respond. Not even Gianto.

Lebronikos gaped and pinched his forearm. All his elaborate theories had dissolved into nothing.

Tila glanced back, seeking Ronalkis's support. He gave her an encouraging nod, and so she continued. She said it all.

"Well... all that mystery... We made it up. We just did it to get on your nerves," she confessed.

"We apologise."

Zlathano tore the leaf in his hand into tiny green confetti, his gaze fixed on the orange sphere behind Zako's boot.

"Might we join your game? If the Ballos would permit it?" he said, surprising even himself with the words that came out of his mouth.

Lesla's hair lashed across her shoulders like red silk threads as she whirled toward Joras.

"So now what? Are we supposed to just forgive them?" she asked her jaw tense. "Just pretend the past never happened?"

"No... I mean, yes." He shrugged. "They did show us the basket, Lesla..."

"Actions speak louder than words," Gianto added. "And theirs just shouted."

"Lesla does have a point, but I place my trust in that," Clara said, pointing to the Flipeans' golden-yellow wings, a color as rare as an apology from their lips. "I think... I think they've earned a chance."

Lesla let her hands fall loosely, yielding, for this was an argument she couldn't refute.

All eyes found Zako, like sunflowers to the sun. He kept his gaze fixed on the scattered stones and autumn debris at his feet, as if they held ancient wisdom.

Then, Danko lunged with a sudden leap into Tila's arms, making the Ballos' position crystal clear. Her startled gasp melted into a smile as she pressed her nose against his cheek.

Zako's familiar crooked smile crinkled the corners of his amber-flecked eyes.

"Your apology is accepted," he said, extending his hand across Tila.

She clasped it immediately. Her fingers, unexpectedly warm, wrapped around his, and in that moment, as earth met sky in a handshake that would change everything, the first seeds of something wonderful took root in the soil of Eterlivo.

Leonessis stared at Vinira's glistening cheeks. "This day holds more wonders than I imagined possible," he said, a faint smile tugging at his lips.

Meanwhile, Joras had pivoted away his shoulders hunched as he swiped at his face.

"Blasted gnats," he muttered, though no insects buzzed nearby. When he finally turned back, his voice wobbled despite his obvious attempts to control it.

"Alright then... but no wings!" his voice wobbled. "The game we'll be fair!"

"Exactly!" announced an unfamiliar voice that seemed to come from everywhere and nowhere, as if carved into the very air.

A chill swept through the clearing, bringing with it the unmistakable scent of authority. Their plain, muted clothing blended seamlessly with the surrounding bark and stone, and somehow enhanced rather than diminished their regal bearing.

As they advanced in measured steps, the grass itself seemed to yield, creating a natural pathway. Silver whistles resembling badges of high office hung from thick chains around their necks. These swung like pendulums with every step, emitting startling flashes with each deliberate movement.

The Frifies had arrived.

Whispers fell silent and the leaves ceased rustling when Colinaris, their leader with chiselled features, stood in the centre of the clearing. His companions took their places to his left and right, forming a perfect geometric triangle.

“Our observations have been... thorough,” he announced. The sunlight glinted on his bare scalp, contrasting sharply with the icy blue of his eyes.

“Rest assured, the rules will be enforced,” he continued after a calculated pause.

“Teams of five. The Ballo must bounce after every two steps. Fail to do so and the points will not count.”

He closed his fingers around the whistle hanging from his neck and gave it a sharp shake. “When you hear this, you stop. Instantly. No objections.”

His gaze bored into each of their faces as though reading the depths of their souls.

“Is that clear?”

They responded with nothing but solemn nods, like students facing the world’s strictest headmaster.

“I think even my wings are paralysed,” Tila whispered, barely moving her lips.

Beside her, Zako nodded, his expression just as grave. “Me too. And I don’t even have wings.” Tila pressed her lips together, biting back a laugh.

Colinaris remained silent, sweeping his eyes over them for a moment longer. Then a genuine, kind smile softened his features, erasing all traces of severity.

“You have ten minutes to get ready,” he said in a surprisingly calm voice.

They surged into the clearing like a tidal wave. On one side, Zako gathered his teammates into a close circle. Their hushed strategy session was punctuated by the occasional nod and pointed finger. Across from them, Tila directed her team through quick practice shots.

As the minutes passed, Colinaris positioned himself in the centre with Jumbi's vibrant orange form balanced in his raised palm. His whistle was poised between his lips.

Zako stood rigidly to his right, jaw clenched in concentration, while Tila stood on his left, her wings twitching like a metronome fuelled by adrenaline. Their teammates crouched in ready stances with slightly bent knees, racing hearts and gazes locked on the sphere that would soon set everything in motion.

The whistle pierced the air, and Jumbi soared skyward from Colinaris's palm. Zako and Tila sprang towards the sphere, their bodies stretching like twin catapults. Though their hands grazed Jumbi simultaneously, it was Zako's fingers that claimed possession by the slimmest margin.

"Go!" Lesla shouted, snagging Jumbi in mid-air as she darted between the Flipeans. The Spartheans moved as one fluid entity, finding openings where none seemed to exist.

"Guard the perimeter!" Tila directed, her voice straining. "No! Cover the centre!" she cried, as the Flipeans struggled to coordinate. But during the break, they regrouped. In the second half, the Flipeans surged forward, narrowing the wide point gap.

With the final whistle moments away, Joras charged forward. His long legs propelled him across the field like an unstoppable steam engine, eating up the distance to the basket with each stride.

The spectators' cheers dissolved into a distant hum and were replaced by the steady bounce of the Ballo against the ground and the palms, echoing in his ears like a second heartbeat.

With every breath burning like fire in his lungs, he took two giant steps and soared. High. Very high. At the apex, with his fingertips brushing the rim, he hung suspended in that weightless instant, as though he had wings. Then, with a flick of his wrist, he sent Danko sailing through the hoop in a perfect arc.

The shrill blast of Colinaris's whistle cut through the air, unleashing a storm of Sparthean celebration. They leapt skyward with outstretched arms, spinning and colliding in a joyful blur before finally collapsing beneath the canopy of the ancient oak, where the Flipeans sat with their wings trailing on the grass.

Vinira emptied her water flask over her face. "Such disgrace..." she muttered, flicking moisture from her temples.

With damp strands of hair stuck to his forehead, Ronalkis observed Joras's quivering limbs with undisguised fascination. "How on earth did you pull that off?" he asked.

Lesla's blue eyes sparkled as she offered a conspiratorial wink. "With our wings, of course!" she teased, coaxing an unwilling smile from Ronalkis.

Zlathano flexed his crimson-gold wings. "Acceptable today... however, next time--"

"Next time what? Will you lose more cutely?" Joras cut in, his grin spreading as he swept back his soaked locks.

The laughter that followed warmed the clearing and their hearts like a summer breeze. Even the Frifies couldn't resist smiling. Initial tentative handclasps evolved into wholehearted embraces, which marked the day's true victory beyond any scoreboard.

Zako's proposal to name the clearing 'Springfield', combining the names of their two villages in tribute to a new beginning and the union of their strengths, was met with unanimous approval.

The Ballos leapt into the air and clapped against one another midair. They landed awkwardly, tumbled into the grass, and burst into laughter.

Eterlivo became a magical place that day, where everyone had wings. The kind that don't need feathers to fly. Lost in their revelry, no one noticed the tender green shoot unfurling from the ancient olive tree's gnarled roots. The first in centuries.

After that day, their lives fell into a pattern of shared joy. Arguments still flared up, but twilight always found them together. Sometimes they huddled among the oak's exposed roots, and on other nights they perched on Fieldburg's highest balconies. They exchanged stories of spectacular catches and near misses, planned tomorrow's adventures and ventured to hidden grottos and cliff-top meadows that were previously known only to winged creatures.

Until one afternoon when the cheerful chirping of birds, the welcoming rustle of leaves, and all the sounds of the forest ceased.

Chapter 2

Gianto blinked as he looked out of the window at the pale yellow light that was staining the world outside. He ran over to the large stone oven, where Zako and Joras were kneading bread.

He flung open the door with such force that it slammed against the wall, rattling the nearby copper pots.

“Have you seen what’s happening out there?”

Zako and Joras abandoned their work, leaving traces of flour on their aprons, and stepped outside.

The sky had turned a deep, bruised purple, and the clouds hung so low that they almost touched Lebronikos, Lesla, and Clara, who were rushing towards the oven. Zako’s eyes swept the clearing from edge to edge. His fingers twitched restlessly.

“The Ballos,” he said. “Where are they?”

They searched everywhere. They pushed aside ferns, thrust their hands into hollow tree trunks, and called their names again and again until their throats were raw, but there was no answer.

Only silence. And it didn’t even feel like the silence they knew.

Lesla reached for Zako, who had gone pale as chalk. “They must have gone to Fieldburg. Don’t worry” she said, but cries for help drowned her out, echoing from afar.

Out of the thick mist emerged the Flipeans, running in blind panic. Their wings hung limply behind them, listless and almost translucent.

Tila reached back and lifted her wing; its delicate veins looked shattered.

“They’re ruined... All of ours!” she exclaimed, dropping her wing uselessly behind her.

Lebronikos dragged his palms down his face, stretching his skin until his eyes became bloodshot half-moons.

“So... it’s not enough that we lost the Ballos... now we’ve lost your wings too?”

Zlathano whirled towards him. “What?! What do you mean you lost the Ballos?”

A deafening clap of thunder swallowed his words as lightning cleaved the clouded sky, casting everything in a momentary, harsh white glow. The wind suddenly surged, whipping the Flipeans' wings like broken kites until they were torn away and scattered into the distance.

Their knees buckled instantly. The Spartheans lunged to catch them before they could collapse into the mud. Zako gripped Tila tightly around her slender waist. For a fleeting second, he feared she might break too, just like her wings. She clung to him, and he felt his heart wrench as her tears soaked into his shoulder.

The first raindrop hit the ground, leaving a dark stain that spread through the soil. Then another followed. Within the next heartbeat, it was as if the sky had torn open unleashing a storm unlike anything Eterlivo had ever seen.

“Run!” Zako shouted, pointing towards the olive tree, which seemed to be the only safe refuge.

With tears streaming down their faces and rain hitting them like tiny needles, they could barely see a few feet ahead. The gale-force wind pushed them back, their feet sinking ankle-deep into the churning mud, leaving deep footprints that were instantly filled with brown water, erasing all trace of their passage.

They fell to their knees beneath the olive tree, gasping for breath. Rainwater dripped from their hair and clothes, creating puddles on the ground, which had somehow remained dry under the leafy canopy.

All of a sudden the storm ceased, giving way to a gentle breeze that stroked their wet cheeks. It carried the sweet scent of rain-drenched grass and damp earth, making them feel safe, if only for a moment.

But then, a voice spoke. "Welcome."

They scrambled to their feet, their hearts hammering, their eyes darting between the shadows. Martina clutched her hands to her chest, pressing against the fabric of her shirt, which moved with each heartbeat. Leonessis whirled his head around so sharply that droplets of water sprayed everywhere. But there was no one to be seen.

Only Tila stood motionless with her back against the tree trunk, pointing behind her.

Zako frowned. He had no idea what she was trying to tell him.

"The tree talks." she mouthed.

Lebronikos recoiled, tracing the swirling patterns in the ancient bark with wide eyes until he backed into Ronalkis. They wobbled precariously before a branch curved down like a shepherd's staff, steadying them with the lightest touch.

The branches creaked, and the voice resonated once more.

"His spells withered my roots and turned brother against brother. They made peace, and my branches flourished again. Bre would never tolerate such joy... such defiance would not go unpunished."

Gianto's blood ran cold.

"Bre?! The one who wove sunlight into songs? Whose laughter was the spark that ignited the dawn across the Seven Valleys? Then the ancient scrolls speak truth?"

He spoke in a single breathless rush, much like he did when staying up past midnight with a candle burning low, hunched over his grandfather's leather-bound book of legends. "The silver-tongued one who craved the glittering threads of destiny? Gaia's beloved counsellor who whispered poison into her ear plunging a dagger of betrayal into her heart to take her place, and was then exiled? That Bre?"

"The very same," the Olive Tree confirmed. "He is cunning. He wanders the realms sowing misery, destroying whatever the world learns to love most. The world is in peril... and that part is not written in your books."

A single raindrop slipped from a branch. It was the only thing that moved. It slid downward, catching their terrified faces in its curve for a heartbeat before it fell into a shallow hollow in the earth, sending thin ripples across the pooled water.

"What we do? How we take all back?" Tila asked.

"His castle..." the tree replied. "Those who enter never return."

"We'll go," Zako said curtly.

"And then what? Supposing we actually find him, then what?" Lesla's arm swept towards the others, who were huddled together beneath the branches with their shoulders hunched and their eyes downcast.

"Look at us."

Tila brushed aside a wet strand of hair that clung to her temple, revealing the small brown freckle that Zako loved to poke when he teased her.

She squared her shoulders, wincing slightly as the movement pulled at the raw twin scars on her back where her wings had once been.

“Bemoaning fate changes nothing. And I refuse to accept it,” she said, her voice growing stronger with each syllable.

Zako moved to her side, feeling his pulse beat like a distant war drum.

“The fire of our ancestors’ battles still burns in our chests. I know it does,” he declared, pressing a mud-stained fist against his heart.

His eyes found the Spartheans, their shoulders slumped in defeat. “I don’t remember any of us ever leaving someone behind.”

Then he turned to the Flipeans, their skin as dull as stones washed too long in a stream. “Since when do you hand over your wings without a fight?”

His voice spread like a rising gale.

“We were made for more than this! More than giving up!”

Tila’s eyes, black as coal with a bright flame burning in their depths, moved deliberately over each of them in turn. Clara’s lower lip ceased trembling when Tila’s gaze met hers. Ronalkis lifted his chin from his chest and the furrow between his brows smoothed away.

“We will take back what belongs to us,” Tila cried. “We will fight for our wings! For our Ballos! For our right to be happy!”

“Yes!” they shouted in a thunderous chorus, punching their fists into the air and stomping their feet.

But Lebronikos stopped abruptly, his enthusiasm waning as quickly as it had ignited. “But where do we even start? How?”

A tightly coiled branch creaked as though a key was turning in an ancient lock, and a faded map fell softly to the ground. Then, like a creeping dawn, a soft luminescence gathered at its centre coalescing into a figure woven of light and mist.

His chestnut-gold hair fell in long, sunlit threads to his shoulders. His eyes held an otherworldly glint: emerald green in one and sapphire blue in the other.

“I greet you,” he said, bowing.

“Allow me to introduce myself: Xechartes. Your guide... your lighthouse... the answer...”

“Arte!” the Olive Tree interrupted.

“Ah, yes, friends call me Arte.”

His light flickered, then folded back into the parchment. A branch flared into a burning torch as the tree spoke.

“May my spirit be with you when all seems dark. Remember, the wings of the heart can never be stolen.”

The trunk of the olive tree split open with the sound of uncoiling roots, revealing a portal that led into a passageway. At the entrance were well-crafted, identical backpacks. They slung them over their shoulders without a word.

Zako tucked Xechartes into his backpack, while Tila raised the torch high. Together, they were the first to step through the doorway. One by one, the others followed.

The golden torchlight flickered across their faces, bringing warmth to the darkness ahead.

Their shadows danced on the walls and each footstep echoed softly in the silence.

Joras tightened the strap of his satchel. “Charming tunnels,” he joked, though his jaw was trembling.

“We won’t be afraid,” whispered Tila, though she gripped her own arms a little tighter.

Their shadows grew smaller as they ventured deeper into the unknown, and Tila reached for Zako’s hand. He smiled at her, a smile that spoke of someone who knew hope

was worth more than fear. They turned their heads for one last look back just before the doorway swallowed the last sliver of light from the world they were leaving behind.